

THE AI AUTOMATION STARTER KIT

Seven Automations You Can Build Without Code

Seven small automations that take the busywork off your mornings.

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Why this exists

There is a particular kind of work that eats your day without leaving a mark on it. You read the same kind of email and write the same kind of reply. You take the same notes after every call and type them into the same task list. You open the same spreadsheet every Friday and turn it into the same report. None of it is hard. That is exactly the problem. Work that is easy and repetitive is work a machine should be doing, and now it can.

For years, connecting your apps to each other meant hiring someone who could write code. That barrier is gone. Two tools, Zapier and Make, let you wire your apps together by clicking through a visual builder, the same way you would fill out a form. The new part is that both of them now plug a real AI model directly into that wiring. So the robot you build does not just move data from one box to another. It can read, summarize, decide, and write, which is the work that used to require you.

This guide gives you seven automations a normal professional can set up without writing a single line of code. Each one removes a specific piece of daily busywork. For each, you get the painful task it kills, exactly how to wire it, and an honest estimate of the time it gives back. Start with one. Get it working. The confidence you gain from the first will carry you through the next six.

A note on truth, because there is a lot of breathless nonsense online about this. Everything here is built on what these tools actually do as of mid-2026, drawn from the vendors' own documentation. Where there is a cost or a limit you should know about before you start, this guide tells you plainly instead of pretending automation is free and infinite. It is neither, and the honest version is still very much worth your time.

A two-minute primer on the two tools

Zapier is the friendlier of the two and the right place to start. You build "Zaps." A Zap has a trigger ("when a new email arrives") and one or more actions ("summarize it," "send me a Slack message"). The trigger and every action are chosen from menus. Zapier also ships a built-in AI step called AI by Zapier that can summarize text, classify it, pull data out of it, translate it, and draft replies, all powered by an included AI model so you do not need your own AI account to use it. The free plan gives you 100 tasks a month and single-action Zaps, which is enough to learn but not to run a business on. Multi-step Zaps and the heavier AI features start on the paid plans. As of June 15, 2026, the AI steps are priced in tiers, where a basic AI step costs one task and a more powerful reasoning step costs more, so it pays to use the lightest model that does the job.

Make (formerly Integromat) is more powerful and a little more technical, and it shows you your automation as a visual flowchart of connected circles called a "scenario." Make has

native modules for the major AI providers, including OpenAI and Anthropic's Claude, and on paid plans it lets you bring your own AI account to keep costs down. Make runs on credits, where each step in a scenario spends one credit, and the free plan includes 1,000 credits a month, which goes surprisingly far for personal use.

You do not need both. Use Zapier for the first few automations below. Reach for Make when you want more control or you are running something at higher volume.

1. The inbox that triages itself

The busywork it kills: Every morning you open a full inbox and spend the first hour just sorting it. Which of these actually needs me, which is a quick yes, which is noise, which can wait. The reading-to-decide is the tax, and you pay it before you have done any real work.

How to wire it: In Zapier, the trigger is a new email in Gmail or Outlook. The next step is an AI by Zapier "Classify" action, where you give it your own categories in plain English: "Urgent and needs my decision," "Quick reply I can send myself," "FYI only," "Newsletter or promotion." The AI reads the email and picks the right bucket. Then you add a simple action for each bucket. Urgent emails get starred and pushed to you as a Slack or text message. FYI emails get a label and skip your attention entirely. You are not asking the AI to answer anything yet. You are asking it to do the sorting you do by hand, so that when you open your inbox the triage is already done.

Before and after: Before, you spend forty to sixty minutes a day reading email just to decide what each one is. After, you open an inbox that is already sorted, and you go straight to the handful that genuinely need you. Realistic time saved: thirty to forty-five minutes every working day.

2. Form responses that come back as drafted replies

The busywork it kills: A contact form, a quote request, or an application comes in. You read it, you figure out what they are asking, and you write back more or less the same kind of message you wrote yesterday and the day before. The reply is not identical, so you cannot use a canned template, but it is close enough that writing it from scratch every time is a waste.

How to wire it: The trigger is a new submission in your form tool, whether that is Google Forms, Typeform, or Jotform. The next step sends the person's answers to an AI step, in Zapier or to Make's Claude module, with a clear instruction: "A potential client submitted this inquiry. Draft a warm, specific reply that answers their question, references the detail they mentioned, and invites them to book a call. Keep it under 150 words and match the tone of the examples below." You paste in two or three of your own best past replies so it copies your voice. The crucial last step is the safety valve. The draft does not get sent. It lands in your email as a ready-to-review draft, or as a Slack message you approve. You read it, tweak a word if needed, and hit send.

Before and after: Before, ten to twelve minutes to read each inquiry and write a thoughtful, personalized reply. After, thirty seconds to read a draft that already sounds like you and already addresses their specific question. Across a week of inbound, that is a few hours back, and your response time to new leads drops from hours to minutes, which is its own quiet advantage.

3. Meeting notes that turn themselves into a task list

The busywork it kills: The call ends. Now you have to remember what everyone agreed to, write it down, figure out who owns what, and get those items into wherever your tasks actually live. Half the time this never happens, and a commitment quietly evaporates between the meeting and the next one.

How to wire it: Use an AI meeting assistant that auto-joins your calls, such as Fireflies, Fathom, or Otter. These tools record the meeting and produce a transcript and a list of action items on their own. The automation picks up where they stop. The trigger is "new meeting transcribed." The next step feeds the transcript to an AI step with an instruction like: "From this transcript, list every commitment made, who owns it, and the deadline if one was mentioned. Then list any open questions that were not resolved." The final steps route the output where it belongs. Commitments become tasks in Asana, Todoist, or Notion. Open questions go into a follow-up note. The clean summary lands in your team's Slack channel.

Before and after: Before, fifteen to twenty minutes of post-meeting cleanup per call, assuming you do it at all. After, the task list is waiting in your project tool before you have left the room, with owners and dates already attached. For someone with three or four meetings a day, that is an hour back daily and, more valuable, a sharp drop in dropped balls.

4. The weekly report that drafts itself from the spreadsheet

The busywork it kills: Every Friday or every Monday, you open the same spreadsheet, stare at the numbers, and translate them into the same kind of written update for your boss or your team. The numbers change, the structure never does, and writing the narrative around them by hand is an hour you resent.

How to wire it: This one runs on a schedule rather than an event. In Zapier or Make, set a weekly trigger for Friday morning. The next step reads the relevant rows from your Google Sheet or Airtable. Then an AI step receives those numbers with an instruction like: "You are writing this week's status update for a busy executive. Using the data below, write a short report covering the three numbers that moved most, what likely drove each, and one thing to watch next week. Lead with the headline, keep it under 250 words, and do not invent any reasons the data does not support." The draft is delivered to your email or a Slack channel for you to review and send. That last instruction about not inventing reasons matters. The AI should report the numbers and flag what changed, while you supply the real-world context only you know.

Before and after: Before, forty-five to sixty minutes every week turning a grid of numbers into readable prose. After, five minutes to review a solid first draft and add the one or two insights the spreadsheet cannot see. Roughly forty hours a year, returned.

5. Support messages that tag and route themselves

The busywork it kills: Incoming support requests, whether from a shared inbox, a help desk, or a contact form, all land in one undifferentiated pile. Someone has to read each one, decide what it is about, judge how urgent it is, and send it to the right person. That triage is slow, it is boring, and when it is late the angry ones get angrier.

How to wire it: The trigger is a new ticket or message in your help tool, such as a shared Gmail label, Zendesk, or Freshdesk. An AI step reads the message and does two jobs at once. First it classifies the topic into your own categories: billing, technical issue, refund, sales question, other. Then it judges urgency and tone, flagging anything that reads as angry or threatens to cancel. Based on those two outputs, the automation routes the message. Billing questions go to the billing person, technical ones to support, and anything flagged as a frustrated customer jumps the queue with an alert to a manager. You

can add a step that drafts a suggested first reply for the agent to approve, which speeds up the response without taking the human out of the loop.

Before and after: Before, a few minutes of reading and routing per ticket, multiplied across every ticket, plus the cost of the urgent ones that sat unseen. After, every message is tagged, prioritized, and on the right desk within a minute of arriving, untouched by a human until a human is actually needed. For a small team this is the difference between drowning and keeping pace.

6. Blog posts that become a week of social posts

The busywork it kills: You publish something good, a blog post, an article, a newsletter, and then you face the second job nobody enjoys. You have to rewrite it into posts for LinkedIn, X, and wherever else you show up, each in a different length and a different tone, and you have to do it five times. So most of the time you post the link once and the work disappears.

How to wire it: The trigger fires when you publish, which Zapier and Make can detect from your blog's RSS feed or your newsletter platform. An AI step receives the full article with an instruction like: "Turn this article into a LinkedIn post, three short posts for X, and one short caption for Instagram. Pull the strongest idea from the piece for each one, write in a clear and direct voice, and do not use hashtags or hype. Match the style of the examples below." You paste a few of your own posts so it sounds like you and not like a press release. The drafts land in a spreadsheet or a Slack channel for your review. You keep the good ones, fix the rest, and schedule them. The thinking is done. You are just editing.

Before and after: Before, an hour or more per published piece to manually spin it into platform-specific posts, which is why it so rarely happens. After, ten minutes to review and approve a week's worth of drafts built from work you already did. One good article now does five jobs instead of one.

7. The daily news brief built for you, not for everyone

The busywork it kills: Staying current in your field means a scattered morning ritual of opening a dozen tabs, skimming newsletters, and checking a few industry sources, hoping you do not miss the one thing that actually matters to you. It is twenty minutes of grazing that mostly turns up noise.

How to wire it: Set a scheduled trigger for early each morning. The automation pulls in your sources, which can be a handful of RSS feeds from publications you trust, plus a saved search or two. Those items flow into an AI step with an instruction like: "Here are this morning's headlines and summaries from my industry. Pick the five most important for someone who does what I do, write one tight sentence on each explaining why it matters, and skip anything that is just routine or promotional." The finished brief is delivered to your inbox or your phone before you sit down. Instead of grazing across a dozen sources, you read a one-screen summary built around what is relevant to you specifically.

Before and after: Before, twenty to thirty minutes of scattered skimming every morning, with no guarantee you caught the thing that mattered. After, a ninety-second read of a brief curated to your work, waiting for you when you wake up. Two hours a week back, and a better-informed you for less effort.

The one-page cheat sheet

Pin this somewhere. Build one automation, prove it works, then add the next.

1. **Start with Zapier, not Make.** It is friendlier. Move to Make when you need more power or volume.
2. **Every automation is a trigger plus actions.** "When this happens, do these things." That is the whole model.
3. **Let AI do the reading and the judging.** Summarize, classify, extract, draft. That is the work that used to be yours.
4. **Always keep a human approval step on anything that gets sent.** Drafts, not auto-sends, until you trust it completely.
5. **Show the AI your voice with two or three real examples.** Pasted samples beat any description of your style.
6. **Tell it not to invent.** On any report or summary, add "do not state anything the source does not support."
7. **Mind the meter.** Zapier counts tasks, Make counts credits. Use the lightest AI step that does the job, and check your usage in the first week.
8. **Sequence your build.** Inbox triage and form replies first, since they pay back fastest. The news brief last, since it is the nicest to have and the least urgent.

The point of all of this is not the tools. It is the principle underneath them. Anything you do the same way more than a few times a week is a candidate for a small robot, and you no

longer need an engineer to build that robot. You need an afternoon and the willingness to start with one.

This is a companion to [The Artificial Advantage: Mastering AI in the Modern Workplace](#) by Elvin M. Peters. The book gives you the full framework for putting AI to work across your day, not just your inbox. Get it at elvinpeters.com.

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